

NOTE

If you're using macOS and a pop-up asks you to install the command line developer tools, click **Install**. You may see a message that it will take an excessively long time to install, but it should only take about 10 or 20 minutes on a reasonable internet connection.

Running `hello_world.py`

Before you write your first program, make a folder called `python_work` on your desktop for your projects. It's best to use lowercase letters and underscores for spaces in file and folder names, because Python uses these naming conventions. You can make this folder somewhere other than the desktop, but it will be easier to follow some later steps if you save the `python_work` folder directly on your desktop.

Open VS Code, and close the **Get Started** tab if it's still open. Make a new file by clicking **File ▶ New File** or pressing CTRL-N (⌘-N on macOS). Save the file as `hello_world.py` in your `python_work` folder. The extension `.py` tells VS Code that your file is written in Python, and tells it how to run the program and highlight the text in a helpful way.

After you've saved your file, enter the following line in the editor:

```
hello_world.py print("Hello Python world!")
```

To run your program, select **Run ▶ Run Without Debugging** or press CTRL-F5. A terminal screen should appear at the bottom of the VS Code window, showing your program's output:

```
Hello Python world!
```

You'll likely see some additional output showing the Python interpreter that was used to run your program. If you want to simplify the information that's displayed so you only see your program's output, see Appendix B. You can also find helpful suggestions about how to use VS Code more efficiently in Appendix B.

If you don't see this output, something might have gone wrong in the program. Check every character on the line you entered. Did you accidentally capitalize `print`? Did you forget one or both of the quotation marks or parentheses? Programming languages expect very specific syntax, and if you don't provide that, you'll get errors. If you can't get the program to run, see the suggestions in the next section.

Troubleshooting

If you can't get `hello_world.py` to run, here are a few remedies you can try that are also good general solutions for any programming problem:

- When a program contains a significant error, Python displays a *traceback*, which is an error report. Python looks through the file and tries to identify the problem. Check the traceback; it might give you a clue as to what issue is preventing the program from running.